

MacBook Neo

A gift for Apple fans

What should you expect from a ₹70,000 laptop in 2026?

When I put that question to friends and family at a recent get-together, the answer was quite similar: reliable performance and dependable battery life. And it makes all the sense in the world as these two things matter most on a typical workday, when you are juggling between emails, calls, spreadsheets, and whatnot. But a good laptop in 2026 needs to go beyond just the essentials. Design and display, build quality, portability, and even how quietly it fits into your daily routine, all matter as well. And the Apple MacBook Neo, has ticked most of these boxes.

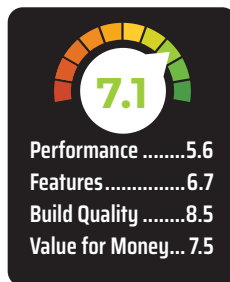
So when I pulled out the NEO toy in town in front of my peers and mentioned that this has been my daily work machine, and I use it for some light gaming as well. And, it costs less than an iPhone 17; the reaction was major curiosity. How could a laptop this compact and relatively affordable keep up with a demanding routine?

PREMIUM DESIGN AND NON-BACKLIT KEYBOARD

For years, a MacBook has been synonymous with being a premium-looking laptop that is meant to be carried into any board meeting with confidence. But with the Neo, Apple is clearly hoping that the laptop isn't just carried to board meetings, but classes as well. Yes, the relatively affordable MacBook Neo also has students as its target consumers and that is clear from the exciting colour options that we have.

One of the best things about the Neo is how compact it is. Compared to

₹69,900



a 13-inch M1 MacBook Air, the Neo is slightly thicker, but also smaller. Despite that, both weigh the same. The result is a machine that feels solid, portable, and well-packed for its size.

Coming to the build quality, there is absolutely nothing to complain about.

The new laptop maintains Apple's reputation and will make you wonder how such a premium-feeling device cost less than ₹70,000.

The unit I received is the base variant, which does not have a Touch ID button at the top right. Instead, there is a button to lock the laptop and unlock it by entering your password. Over the years, I have grown accustomed to Touch ID and not having it looks sort of incomplete. But then, if you are a first-time MacBook user, this ideally shouldn't matter much.

Meanwhile, the keyboard is placed neatly on the chassis and I had no issues switching from my MacBook Air 15-inch to this one. In less than a day, I could type without having to look down at the keyboard. The keys are super

responsive and have a tactile feel that results in a satisfactory experience. They are also silent, so even when you're typing with full gusto, others at the workplace won't hear you.

Of course, it's a shame the keyboard isn't backlit, and when you work or study late at night, this can be an issue. There are workarounds, like buying a small mini USB LED light, but having a backlit keyboard would have been ideal.

The touchpad is decently sized and utilises the chassis perfectly. However, it is also a physical one, not the one with haptic feedback. So the moment you press it to click, it moves.

Finally, let's talk about the port options. There are two USB-C ports on the left and either can be used for charging. However, if you want to connect an external display, you can use only one port. Apart from this, there is a 3.5 mm headphone jack for connecting wired accessories.

DISPLAY

People all around the world trust MacBooks' display when it comes to colour accuracy. But can you expect the same display quality in Apple's most affordable laptop yet? Absolutely.

The MacBook Neo's display can show up to 1 billion colours and sticks to the sRGB colour space. It does not extend to wider gamuts like DCI P3. Now, will that really impact a student or someone using it for everyday work? In most cases, no. But for users dealing with colour-critical work, it could make a difference. For users who want to get through their workday, consume OTT content or even indulge in some light gaming, the display is quite good.

PERFORMANCE

Since the MacBook Neo is powered by an A18 Pro chip, which is found on iPhone 16 Pro and has just 8 GB of RAM, you won't really expect it to excel at gaming. But it does a pretty good job.